native origins, but also to counter and distinguish its mainstream from Arya Samaj and other socio-religious reform movements

- As such, the term never caught on in south India, where 'Hindu' and 'Hinduism' remained the common terms, just like they did with the bulk of its adherents elsewhere. It even birthed the term 'Hindutva'

- In the south, Sanatana dharma is often seen as synonymous with 'Brahminical hegemony', as distinct from common people's faith. Even Udhayanidhi Stalin said as much, asserting he had not spoken about Hindus, only "evil practices and inequality"

closet in the past two decades and now seldom hide their beliefs.

So, has the arrival of self-professed Sanatana adherents revived a moribund political pitch? Thol. Thirumavalavan, founder of the Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (formerly known as the Dalit Panthers), an electoral ally of the DMK, is not surprised. He was one of the first to target Sanatana dharma in the Tamil Nadu political discourse, beginning at a public rally in Tiruchi before the 2019 Lok Sabha election.

But he says he chose the issue to side-step the problem of being described as anti-Hindu. "When we attack Hindutva, they twist it around to make it seem like we are speaking against ordinary Hindus, with their beliefs in the gods and the Puranas," says the VCK chief. "To me, Sanatana dharma is the basic concept of an Aryan religion. Inequality is at the core of it, creating differences and social hierarchy based on birth." He believes the BJP wants to further the Sanatana dharma concept in the state.

Religion has never been an election issue in TN, says Moorthy. "It was a political talking point, but the voter left it at that. Else, the Justice Party first, and the DMK later, would not have come to power." So, what will be the outcome of the current controversy? "On the surface, the BJP will gain traction, but caste questions will haunt the party as it goes into election mode. Even the INDIA bloc will play it both ways, remaining neutral but welcoming the potential for engagement with new caste mobilisations," says political analyst Ramu Manivannan. He believes this will give an invisible handle against the RSS and BJP to several parties, like the RJD and the Samajwadi Party in the north. In the south, the BJP will have to be more defensive and cautious.

Udhayanidhi's comments may have been glossed over, at least in Tamil Nadu, had not the BJP made it a national issue. It has good reasons to do so. There is concern within the DMK as the BJP tries to widen its reach. Firebrand state unit chief K. Annamalai is currently on a state-wide tour, trying to swell the saffron ranks in the run-up to the general election. Tagging Udhayanidhi on X, he said, "You and your father have a bought-out idea from Christian missionaries" and implied they were propagators of that "malicious ideology".

Evidently, Sanatana dharma is creating new meanings in political discourse—it's even being used as an all-encompassing term for religious and spiritual traditions of pre-Islamic India. "These overarching usages are new," says singer-writer-activist T.M. Krishna. "That these have been propagated mainly by Brahminical sections is undeniable. So, the general usage of this term as a synonym for Hinduism is duplicitous." For politicians, though, it is a handy slogan in election season. ■

ANDHRA PRADESH

Naidu in a Tight Corner

By Amarnath K. Menon

The arrest and 14-day judicial remand of Telugu Desam Party (TDP) chief N. Chandrababu Naidu in an election year is a severe setback to the main Opposition party in Andhra Pradesh. Naidu is accused of being the 'principal conspirator' in a case of fraudulent misappropriation of approximately Rs 371 crore belonging to the Andhra Pradesh State Skills Development Corporation (APSSDC). Set up in 2014 during Naidu's tenure as chief minister (2014 to 2019), the APSSDC initiated a project to help unemployed youth by providing them skill training. The allegation is that it was used to siphon off funds from the state exchequer. The Andhra Pradesh Crime Investigation Department (APCID), after an extensive probe, has reportedly discovered that Naidu was in the know of the project from the conceptual stage and had a role in the irregularities.

However, the timing of the arrest early on September 9, when